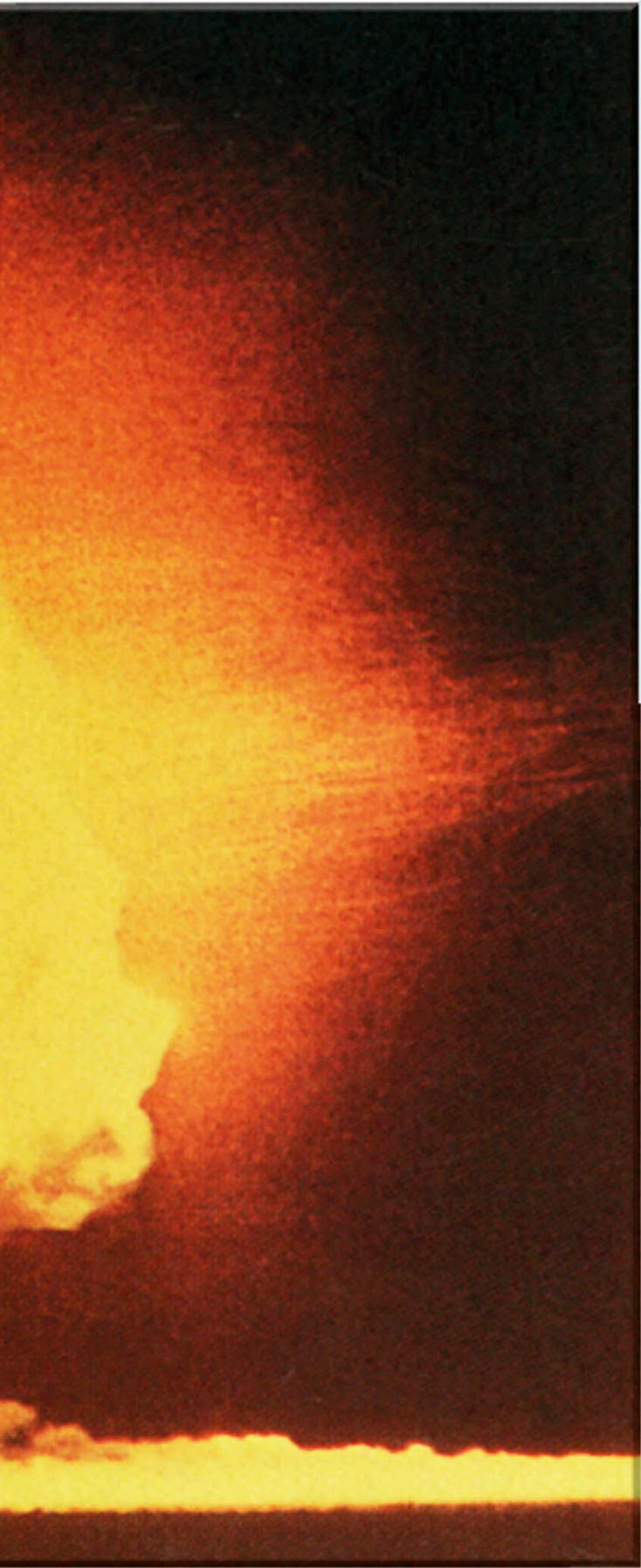


The Trinity Test

On July 16, 1945, the first atomic weapon was detonated in Alamogordo, New Mexico. The test, code-named "Trinity," confirmed the power of an atomic chain reaction caused by the fission (splitting) of the nuclei of plutonium atoms. Within just 16 thousandths of a second, the mushroom cloud created by the blast had grown almost 655 ft (200 m) tall and would loom up more than 41,340 ft (12,600 m) high. The blast, equivalent to nearly 20,500 tons (18,600 metric tons) of TNT explosive, generated so much heat that it melted the sand of the desert floor into glass, which became known as trinitite. The atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima, Japan, followed three weeks later, devastating the city and causing more than 100,000 deaths.

“We knew the world would not be the same. A few people laughed, a few people cried. Most people were silent.”

J. Robert Oppenheimer, director of the Los Alamos Laboratory (founded during World War II, 1939–1945, to develop nuclear weapons), 1965



The mushroom cloud from the blast of the first atomic weapon rises over Alamogordo Bombing Range in New Mexico.